

Grants to USA, Canada, and International Researchers for Research Projects Related to Improving Education

Research Grants on Education: Small

Agency

Foundation

GrantWatch ID#

172494

Funding Source

The Spencer Foundation

Geographic Focus

All USA

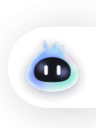
USA Territories: **American Samoa (USA); Guam (USA); Puerto Rico (USA); Virgin Islands (USA); Northern Mariana Islands (USA);**

USA Compact Free Associations: The Federated States of Micronesia (USA) Marshall Islands (USA) Republic of Palau (USA)
International, Israel and Canada.

 Important Dates

Deadline: 04/15/26 12:00 PM Noon CT

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Grant Description

Grants of up to \$50,000 and grants of up to \$60,000 to USA, Canada, and International researchers who are affiliated with nonprofit organizations, such as IHEs, school districts, and research facilities, for research projects in the field of education. Funding is intended to support field-initiated academic research studies spanning a range of disciplines and topics that explore improvements in education. Funded projects may pertain to any stage or level from early childhood to adult learning, and may focus on contexts outside of school.

This program is “field-initiated” in that proposal submissions are not in response to a specific request for a particular research topic, discipline, design, or method. The goal for this program is to support rigorous, intellectually ambitious and technically sound research that is relevant to the most pressing questions and compelling opportunities in education. The Foundation seeks to support scholarship that develops new foundational knowledge that may have a lasting impact on educational discourse.

The Foundation values work that fosters creative and open-minded scholarship, engages in deep inquiry, and examines robust questions related to education. To this end, this program supports proposals from multiple disciplinary and methodological perspectives, both domestically and internationally, from scholars at various stages in their career. The Foundation anticipates that proposals will span a wide range of topics and disciplines that innovatively investigate questions central to education, including for example education, anthropology, philosophy, psychology, sociology, law, economics, history, or neuroscience, among others.

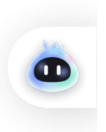
Moreover, the Foundation expects and welcomes methodological diversity in answering pressing questions; thus, they are open to projects that utilize a wide array of research methods including



quantitative, qualitative, mixed-methods, ethnographies, computational modeling, design-based research, participatory methods, and historical research, to name a few. They are open to projects that might incorporate data from multiple and varied sources, span a sufficient length of time as to achieve a depth of understanding, or work closely with practitioners or community members over the life of the project.

Eligible investigators may request additional supplemental funds for a course release.

Recipient



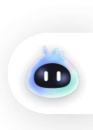
Additional Eligibility Criteria

Principal Investigators (PIs) and Co-PIs applying for a Small Research Grant on Education must have an earned doctorate in an academic discipline or professional field.

The PI must be affiliated with a non-profit organization or public/governmental institution that is willing to serve as the administering organization if the grant is awarded. Examples include non-profit or public colleges, universities, school districts, and research facilities, as well as other non-profit organizations with a 501(c)(3) determination from the IRS (or equivalent non-profit status if the organization is outside of the United States).

Optional Supplemental Course Release: To be eligible, the scholar (PI or Co-PI) must have a course load of 6 or above per academic year.

Proposals are accepted from the U.S. and internationally.



⊗ Ineligible

The Spencer Foundation does not award grants directly to individuals.

Proposals to the Small Research Grants on Education program must be for research projects that aim to study education. Proposals for activities other than research are not eligible (e.g., program evaluations, professional development, curriculum development, scholarships, capital projects, software development). Additionally, proposals for research studies focused on areas other than education are not eligible.

While graduate students may be part of the research team, they may not be named the PI or Co-PI on the proposal.

Budgets may not include indirect cost charges per Spencer's policy.



Pre-Application Information

Timeline:

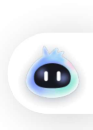
- Applications Open: January 26, 2026
- Full Proposal Deadline: April 15, 2026 (12:00 noon Central time/North America)

All proposals must be submitted in English, and budgets must be proposed in U.S. Dollars.

PIs and Co-PIs may only hold one active research grant from the Spencer Foundation at a time. (This restriction does not apply to the administering organization; organizations may submit as many proposals as they like as long as they are for different projects and have different research teams.)

PIs and Co-PIs may not submit more than one research proposal to the Spencer Foundation at a time. This restriction applies to the Small Grants Program, Large Grants Program, Racial Equity Research Grants Program, and Research-Practice Partnership Program. If the PI or any of the Co-PIs currently have a research proposal under consideration in any of these programs, they are required to wait until a final decision has been made on the pending proposal before they can submit a new proposal.

Policy: <https://www.spencer.org/resources/Applicant-Information-and-Policies>



Estimated Size of Grant

Proposed budgets for this program are limited to \$50,000 total.

The Spencer Foundation recognizes that scholars' course loads vary significantly across the field creating differential contexts and capacities for research projects. To help mitigate these uneven demands on time, the PI or Co-PI may request supplemental course release funds of up to \$10,000 over and above the \$50,000 Small Grant budget limit, for a total of up to \$60,000.

Term of Contract

The proposed project duration can be up to 5 years. Teams should plan to begin their project timeline no sooner than 8 months from the original proposal submission deadline.

Contact Information

Apply online: https://spencer.smartsimple.us/s_Login.jsp

Program contact: smallgrants@spencer.org

The Spencer Foundation
625 N Michigan Ave, Suite 1600
Chicago, IL 60611
312-337-7000



RFP & Supporting Documents

① Before starting your grant application, please review the funding source's website listed below for updates / changes / addendums / conferences / LOIs.

 https://www.spencer.org/grant_types/small-research-grant.pdf

Categories

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